

Award
FINRA Dispute Resolution Services

In the Matter of the Arbitration Between:

Claimant

Steven Damiani

Case Number: 25-01517

vs.

Respondents

Janney Montgomery Scott LLC

Steven Alfred Pitassi

Richard Anthony Ranone

Kristen Laura Verdeaux

Hearing Site: Providence, Rhode Island

Awards are rendered by independent arbitrators who are chosen by the parties to issue final, binding decisions. FINRA makes available an arbitration forum—pursuant to rules approved by the SEC—but has no part in deciding the award.

Nature of the Dispute: Customer vs. Member and Associated Persons

This case was decided by an all-public panel.

REPRESENTATION OF PARTIES

For Claimant Steven Damiani: W. Mark Russo, Esq. and Samantha C. Ferrucci, Esq., Ferrucci Russo, PC, West Warwick, Rhode Island.

For Respondents Janney Montgomery Scott LLC, Steven Alfred Pitassi, Richard Anthony Ranone, and Kristen Laura Verdeaux: Theodore R. Snyder, Esq. and Jackson C. Yates, Esq., Davis Wright Tremaine LLP, New York, New York.

CASE INFORMATION

Statement of Claim filed by Claimant on or about: August 1, 2025.

Steven Damiani signed the Submission Agreement: July 23, 2025.

Statement of Answer filed by Respondents on or about: October 27, 2025.

Steven Alfred Pitassi signed the Submission Agreement: October 23, 2025.

Richard Anthony Ranone signed the Submission Agreement: October 23, 2025.

Kristen Laura Verdeaux signed the Submission Agreement: October 24, 2025.

Janney Montgomery Scott LLC signed the Submission Agreement: October 28, 2025.

CASE SUMMARY

In the Statement of Claim, Claimant asserted the following causes of action: violation of FINRA Rule 2010; violation of FINRA Rule 3110; violation of FINRA Rule 4511; negligence; fraudulent misrepresentation; negligent misrepresentation; tortious interference with expectation of inheritance; and equitable indemnity. The causes of action relate to an account that was allegedly intended to be transferred to Claimant after the death of the decedent account holder.

Unless specifically admitted in the Statement of Answer, Respondents denied the allegations made in the Statement of Claim and asserted various affirmative defenses.

RELIEF REQUESTED

In the Statement of Claim, Claimant requested: damages in an unspecified amount based upon the amount of the investment account of the time of surrender, plus interest that would have accrued if the account were properly managed; damages in an amount equal to reasonable attorneys' fees and costs incurred by Claimant in defending an underlying action; interest assessed at the legal rate, if any, then prevailing in the state where the award is rendered, or at the rate set by the Arbitrators; punitive damages; and such other and additional relief deemed just and proper including but not limited to pre-award interest, attorneys' fees and arbitration costs.

In the Statement of Answer, Respondents requested: dismissal of the Statement of Claim in all respects; and that all forum fees in connection with this proceeding be assessed against Claimant.

OTHER ISSUES CONSIDERED AND DECIDED

The Arbitrators acknowledge that they have each read the pleadings and other materials filed by the parties.

AWARD

After considering the pleadings, the testimony and evidence presented at the hearing, and any post-hearing submissions, the Panel has decided in full and final resolution of the issues submitted for determination as follows:

1. Respondents Janney Montgomery Scott LLC, Steven Alfred Pitassi, and Richard Anthony Ranone are jointly and severally liable for and shall pay to Claimant the sum of \$642,000.00 in compensatory damages.
2. Claimant's claims against Respondent Kristen Laura Verdeaux are denied.
3. Any and all claims for relief not specifically addressed herein, including any requests for punitive damages and attorneys' fees, are denied.

FEES

Pursuant to the Code of Arbitration Procedure, the following fees are assessed:

Filing Fees

FINRA Dispute Resolution Services assessed a filing fee* for each claim:

Initial Claim Filing Fee	=\$ 2,000.00
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**The filing fee is made up of a non-refundable and a refundable portion.*

Member Fees

Member fees are assessed to each member firm that is a party in these proceedings or to the member firm that employed the associated persons at the time of the events giving rise to the dispute. Accordingly, as a party, Respondent Janney Montgomery Scott LLC is assessed the following:

Member Surcharge	=\$ 2,600.00
Member Process Fee	=\$ 5,005.00

Contested Motion for Issuance of Subpoena Fees

Fees apply for each decision on a contested motion for the issuance of a subpoena.

One (1) decision on a contested motion for the issuance of a subpoena with one Arbitrator @ \$200.00	=\$ 200.00
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Total Contested Motion for Issuance of Subpoena Fees	=\$ 200.00
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The Panel has assessed \$100.00 of the contested motion for issuance of subpoena fees to Claimant.

The Panel has assessed \$100.00 of the contested motion for issuance of subpoena fees jointly and severally to Respondents Janney Montgomery Scott LLC, Steven Alfred Pitassi, and Richard Anthony Ranone.

Hearing Session Fees and Assessments

The Panel has assessed hearing session fees for each session conducted. A session is any meeting between the parties and the Arbitrators, including a pre-hearing conference with the Arbitrators, which lasts four (4) hours or less. Fees associated with these proceedings are:

One (1) pre-hearing session with a single Arbitrator @ \$675.00/session Pre-Hearing Conference: April 21, 2026	=\$ 675.00
1 session	

One (1) pre-hearing session with the Panel @ \$1,725.00/session Pre-Hearing Conference: December 17, 2025	=\$ 1,725.00
1 session	

Four (4) hearing sessions @ \$1,725.00/session Hearings: August 25, 2026	=\$ 6,900.00
2 sessions	

August 26, 2026

2 sessions

Total Hearing Session Fees	= \$	9,300.00
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The Panel has assessed \$1,200.00 of the hearing session fees to Claimant.

The Panel has assessed \$8,100.00 of the hearing session fees jointly and severally to Respondents Janney Montgomery Scott LLC, Steven Alfred Pitassi, and Richard Anthony Ranone.

All balances are payable to FINRA Dispute Resolution Services and are due upon receipt.

ARBITRATION PANEL

Christine R. Fitzgerald	-	Public Arbitrator, Presiding Chairperson
Arthur J. Giacomarra	-	Public Arbitrator
Sean Alan D'Amico	-	Public Arbitrator

I, the undersigned Arbitrator, do hereby affirm that I am the individual described herein and who executed this instrument, which is my award.

Concurring Arbitrators' Signatures

Christine R. Fitzgerald

Christine R. Fitzgerald
Public Arbitrator, Presiding Chairperson

09/23/2026

Signature Date

Arthur J. Giacomarra

Arthur J. Giacomarra
Public Arbitrator

09/25/2026

Signature Date

Sean Alan D'Amico

Sean Alan D'Amico
Public Arbitrator

09/23/2026

Signature Date

Awards are rendered by independent arbitrators who are chosen by the parties to issue final, binding decisions. FINRA makes available an arbitration forum—pursuant to rules approved by the SEC—but has no part in deciding the award.

September 25, 2026

Date of Service (For FINRA Dispute Resolution Services use only)